



Critical Thinking and Client Presence

Community Experience Team

Introduction to Client Readiness

Professional Presence

1. Maintains a client-ready, consultative demeanor in all interactions.
2. Shows up prepared, punctual, and with the camera on.
3. Maintains composure under pressure and recovers gracefully from unexpected questions.

Critical Thinking

1. Questions assumptions before accepting requirements at face value.
2. Proactively identifies edge cases and downstream risks (e.g., scalability, API reliability).
3. Challenges groupthink diplomatically and constructively.

Professional presence and the ROI of caring

Social capital in the workplace

Power in the workplace is relational, social capital buys promotions. True influence doesn't come from authority or excellence alone; it comes from trust, empathy, and credibility within your team and wider org.

 What this means for you - **sponsorship from senior leaders or influential peers can be a powerful lever for advancement**, beyond just doing good work.

*A study in The Economic and Labour Relations Review found **a strong association between “network-embedded resources” and expectations of a pay rise or job promotion.** - Cambridge University Press & Assessment*

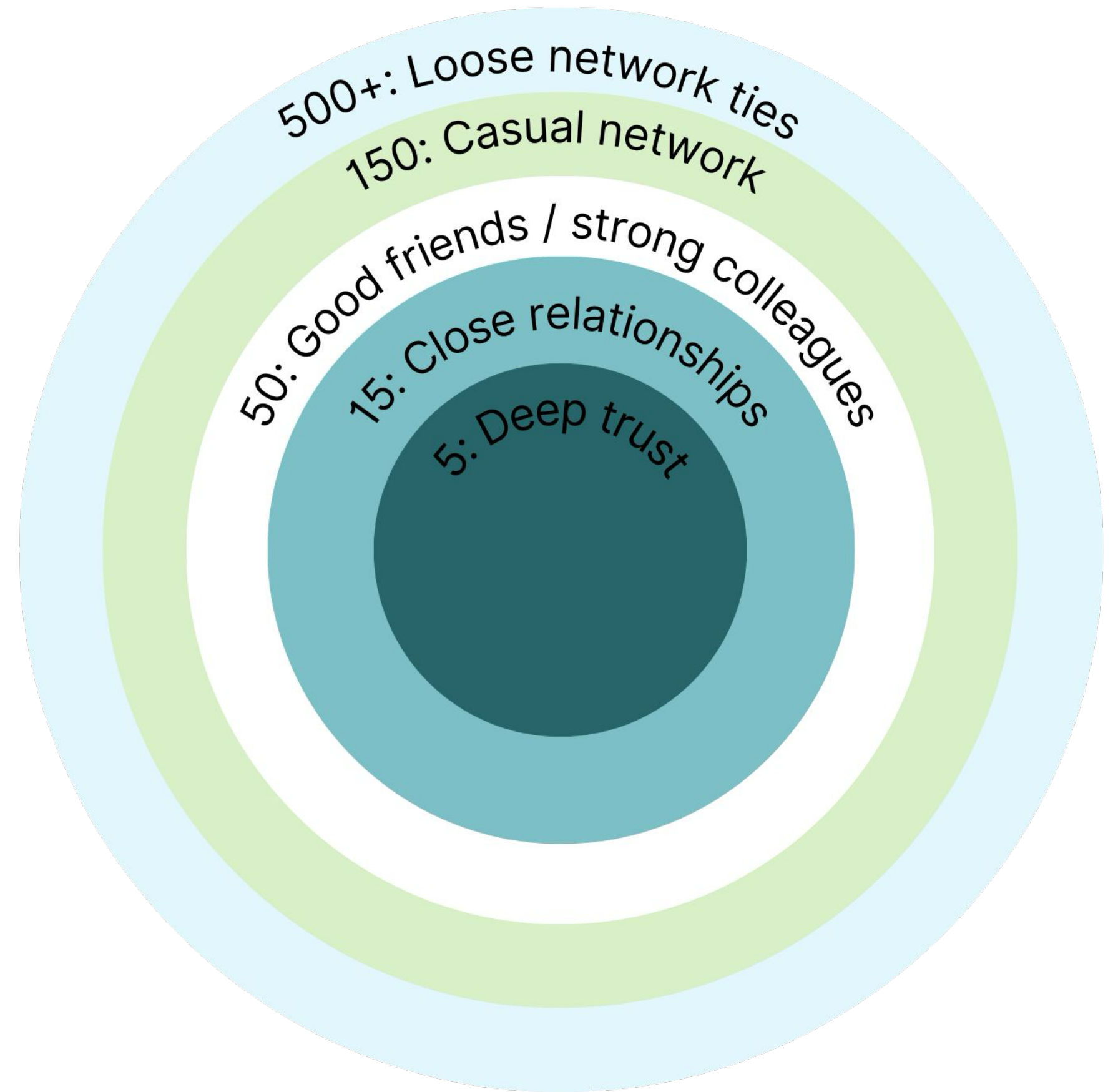
*Employees who feel more connected in their internal networks are **2× more likely to report having sponsorship**, people who actively advocate for their career. - McKinsey & Company*

Dunbar's Social Layering Model

As humans, we only have the bandwidth for a handful of close connections, a moderate number of strong colleagues, and a broader circle of light-touch contacts.

Keep in mind that:

- You can't be close with everyone
- Too many shallow connections = no real social capital
- Be strategic: a few high-value relationships matter most
- Pair this with a culture of everyday, genuine care



The Trust Equation

Maister & Green

$$\text{Trust} = (\text{Credibility} + \text{Reliability} + \text{Intimacy}) / \text{Self-Orientation}$$



Credibility

Your competence and communication



Reliability:

Following through



Intimacy:

Safety in sharing



Self-orientation:

Whether people feel you put yourself first

Composure under pressure

✗ Defensive/Flustered

"Well, I wasn't told to prepare for that." or visibly panicking.

✓ Graceful Recovery

"That is a great question regarding security. While we focused heavily on latency today, let me walk you through our initial data privacy guardrails..."

Baseline: *Camera is always on, background is appropriate, materials are ready, and your tone remains consultative—even when challenged.*

Critical thinking *frameworks*

As AI takes over the “easy stuff,” critical thinking and understanding business context is in demand

Companies are increasingly **looking for engineers who can tackle novel challenges and “figure it out”** when things inevitably deviate from the plan.

The market is demanding that talent excel at:

- ◆ Understanding their contribution to the broader team and business
- ◆ Logical reasoning and decision-making
- ◆ Being resourceful and agile

“

Rising are human strengths like conflict mitigation, adaptability, process automation, and innovative thinking—showing that the future belongs to those who can pair deep AI capabilities with the skills machines can’t replicate.”

Microsoft

Work Trend Index 2025,
The Year the Frontier Firm Is Born

The five whys technique

Why?

Why?

Why?

Why?

Why?

How it works

1. **State the problem:** Clearly define the problem you are trying to solve.
2. **Ask the first "why":** Ask why the problem occurred and write down the answer.
3. **Ask "why" again:** Take the answer from the previous step and ask "why" again.
4. **Continue asking "why":** Repeat this process, asking "why" for each new answer you get.
5. **Identify the root cause:** Continue asking "why" until you reach a root cause that everyone agrees is the fundamental reason for the problem. It may take fewer or more than five "whys" to get to the root cause.
6. **Develop a solution:** Once the root cause is identified, you can develop and implement a solution to address it.

Risk Radar

Before accepting any requirement at face value, ask yourself:

What could go wrong?

Identify edge cases, performance under load, and API reliability

What are we assuming?

Are we assuming the user knows how to prompt the AI? Are we assuming the data is clean?

What is the downstream impact?

How does this technical decision affect the business?

Role play scenario: Constructive pushback

During a planning call, the client's Product Manager proposes a flawed caching approach for the new LLM integration.

You 're the SME and know from experience this approach will cause massive scalability issues down the line.

Task:

Work with your group to draft a response that diplomatically raises your concerns and challenges their approach without making the client feel undermined.

Strategic thinking and goal setting

Open discussion

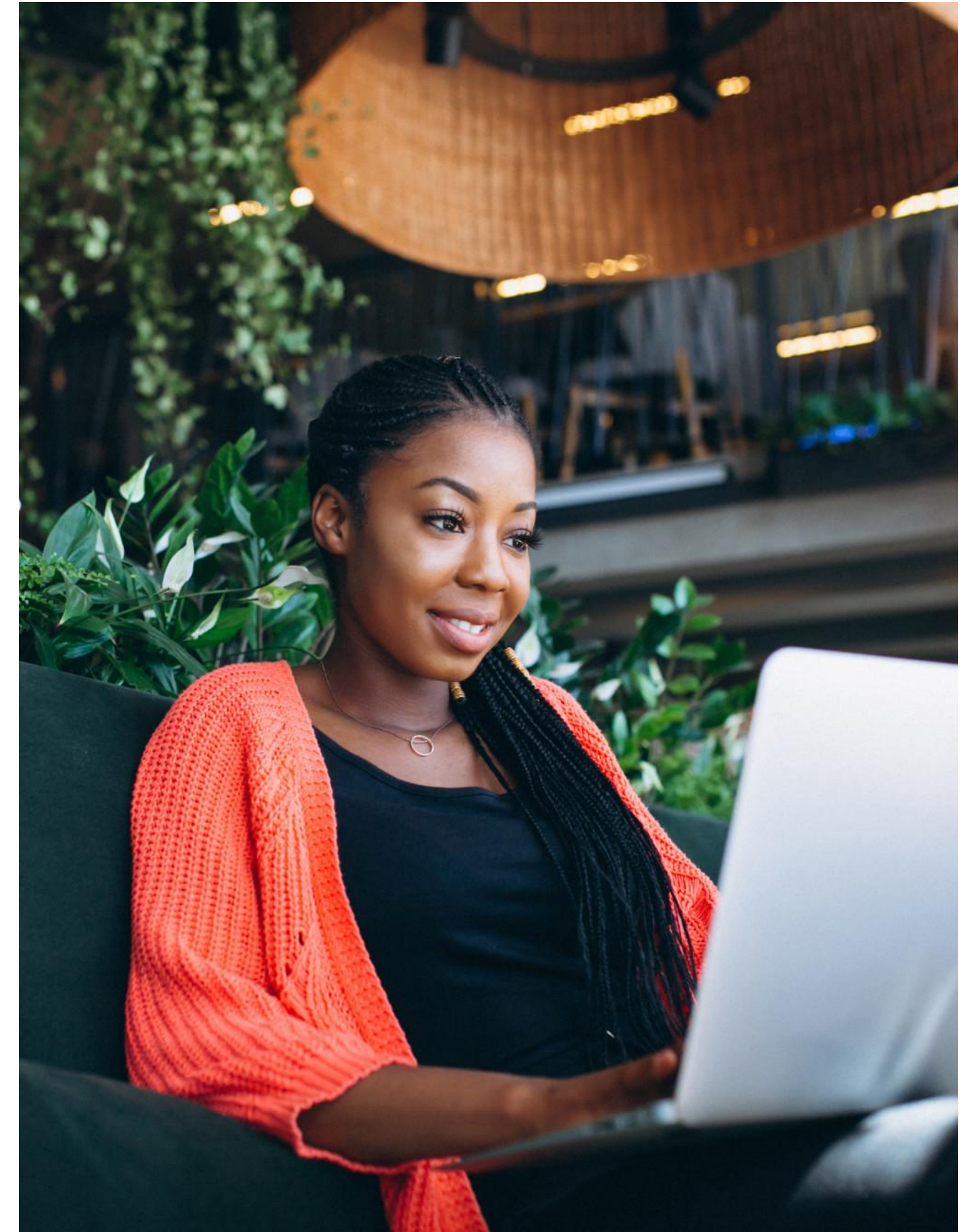
What is strategic
thinking?

Examples of everyday work and the related business outcomes

Code Optimization Benefits → Reduced infrastructure costs, directly improving company profitability and operational expenses.

Workflow Automation Impact → Increased team productivity by streamlining repetitive tasks and enhancing efficiency.

System Reliability Improvement → Higher customer satisfaction and better retention rates.



OKRs and goal setting

$$A + B + C = \text{Objective}$$

Three EPICS that add to your objective

- [] Your objective is only achievable if your EPICS are true
 - [] The number of EPICS is variable, and up to you
- [] If the objective can be achieved without one of the EPICS, then it should not be an EPIC
 - [] Once your objective is set, you can break your EPIC down into “atomic tasks”.

Impact feasibility matrix



What's *next*?

The FDE Behavioral Capstone

Workshops



Practice



Capstone

You will complete a final, high-stakes simulation assessing all B1-B6 dimensions.

- 45 min Solid Road final assignment.
- Three simulations - one interview, two on the job scenarios.
- Only one attempt per simulation.
- Although may receive instant feedback, our team will conduct an internal review before validating and assigning your final score.
- **This will count for 30% of your final grade.**

Pro-Tip: Review your feedback from previous SolidRoad practice simulations to prepare, check your network connection, and raise any technical issues now.

Behavioral competencies

Competencies	Behavioral Scenario (Same Context)
B1: Proactive Initiative	Client mentions order tracking frustration — do you surface the monitoring dashboard idea unprompted?
B2: Ownership & Accountability	Deployment hits a snag — how do you communicate the delay to the client?
B3: Adaptive Problem-Solving	Client changes requirements mid-build — how do you respond to the ambiguity?
B4: Communication of Reasoning	Explain your RAG architecture choice to the non-technical stakeholder
B5: Critical Thinking	Client proposes a flawed caching approach — do you push back constructively?
B6: Professional Presence	Present your completed system to the executive sponsor

Thought exercise

A + B + C = Successful graduation from Andela's AI Bootcamp

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Q&A

